The Russian Revolution and the Rise of the Bolsheviks

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1. The Collapse of the Romanov Dynasty

The Russian Revolution of 1917 was a watershed geopolitical event that dismantled the Tsarist autocracy and led to the eventual creation of the Soviet Union. By early 1917, the Russian Empire was functionally collapsing under the immense strain of World War I. Millions of Russian soldiers had died or deserted due to chronic supply shortages and incompetent military leadership by Tsar Nicholas II. On the home front, a decimated agricultural workforce and a failing railway system caused severe food shortages in major cities. This crisis culminated in the February Revolution (March in the Gregorian calendar), when mass strikes and bread riots in Petrograd (St. Petersburg) forced Nicholas II to abdicate, ending over 300 years of Romanov rule.

2. Dual Power and the Provisional Government

Following the Tsar's abdication, a fragile system of "Dual Power" emerged. On one side was the Provisional Government, composed largely of liberal and moderate socialist politicians from the old Duma (parliament), which sought to establish a Western-style parliamentary democracy and controversially decided to keep Russia in World War I. On the other side was the Petrograd Soviet, a grassroots council elected by workers and soldiers that wielded actual control over the military, transportation, and communications infrastructure. This unstable arrangement severely crippled the state's ability to govern effectively.

3. Vladimir Lenin and the October Revolution

In April 1917, Vladimir Lenin, the leader of the radical Marxist Bolshevik faction, returned to Russia from exile. He vehemently opposed the Provisional Government, issuing the "April Theses" which demanded an immediate end to the war, the confiscation of landed estates, and the transfer of "All Power to the Soviets." The Provisional Government's failure to address the agrarian crisis and its launch of the disastrous Kerensky Offensive in the summer further radicalized the masses. In October 1917, the Bolsheviks, utilizing the armed Red Guard organized by Leon Trotsky, launched a nearly bloodless coup d'état, seizing critical infrastructure in Petrograd and deposing the Provisional Government.

4. The Russian Civil War

The Bolshevik seizure of power immediately triggered a brutal civil war (1918–1922). The newly formed Red Army fought against the "White Army"—a fractured, disorganized coalition of monarchists, conservatives, and moderate socialists supported by foreign interventionist forces (including the US, Britain, and Japan) who sought to keep Russia in WWI and prevent the spread of communism. The Bolsheviks instituted "War Communism," ruthlessly centralizing the economy, nationalizing industry, and forcibly requisitioning grain from the peasantry to feed the Red Army. Through superior organization, control of the industrial heartland, and the ruthless efficiency of the Cheka (secret police), the Bolsheviks ultimately defeated the White forces.

5. Formation of the Soviet Union

In 1922, the victorious Bolsheviks formally established the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR). The revolution completely eradicated the old aristocratic and bourgeois classes, instituting a one-party totalitarian state under the Communist Party. The ideological ramifications of the revolution polarized the 20th century, setting the stage for the global ideological conflict of the Cold War and inspiring numerous communist revolutions and anti-colonial movements worldwide.